



ALEXANDRE YERSIN

Swiss-born French doctor, bacteriologist,
and explorer • 1863–1943

Alexandre Yersin trained in the laboratory of another great bacteriologist, Louis Pasteur. One of Alexandre's first projects was helping to develop a treatment for a disease called rabies. He later used this discovery to save his own life!

In 1890, Alexandre went to work as a doctor in Southeast Asia. He established such a good reputation that, in 1894, the French government asked him to visit nearby Hong Kong to help figure out what was causing the bubonic plague.

Bubonic plague

This nasty disease became known as the "Black Death," after it killed around half of all Europeans in just seven years in the 14th century. Thanks to modern medicine, it is no longer common or fatal.



By 1900, scientists had figured out that flea bites spread bubonic plague from rodents to humans.



Both scientists managed to pinpoint and grow the bacteria that caused the plague. Although Kitasato is thought to have found it first, Alexandre found out more about it. Back in Paris, Alexandre made a medicine called an antiserum, which he used to begin treating patients in Hong Kong in 1896. In the 1970s, the bacteria were renamed *Yersinia pestis* in Alexandre's honor.

Hong Kong was a busy port in the 1890s. Stowed away on the ships, rats brought bubonic plague from Europe.

